

Contents

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Throughout this book: **MASTER STUDY** pages analyse legendary characters, **PROFESSIONAL SECRET** pages carry industry wisdom, and every page closes with a design spark — one hundred of them, no two alike. Read cover to cover, or raid it like a reference shelf. Both are correct.



“

The way to get started is to quit talking
and begin doing.

WALT DISNEY

WHY THIS OPENS THE CHAPTER

This dossier begins with who you are — but it exists so you will draw. Every page of analysis that follows is fuel for a pencil. Read it the way Disney meant it: as the shortest possible route to begin.

IDENTITY · RECORD THREE

The Four Traits

Four words the record-keepers chose for the Visionary — and what each one means when it is yours.

IMAGINATION

See what doesn't exist yet.

FORESIGHT

Sketch tomorrow's shape.

BOLDNESS

Refuse to bow to convention.

HOPE

Keep imagining.

WHY THIS MATTERS — Four traits is a designer's number: one per limb of the silhouette. When you reach the workbook, assign each trait a physical home — a stance, a garment, a prop, a scar — and the abstract becomes drawable.

Movement begins with shape.

PROFESSIONAL SECRET · NO. 1

Professionals don't start with faces.
They start with silhouettes.

A face is a detail. A silhouette is a decision. Every studio pipeline in this book runs in that order.

“

Be wrong as fast as you can.

ANDREW STANTON · PIXAR, WALL-E, FINDING NEMO

WHY THIS OPENS THE CHAPTER

An archetype reading is a first draft of a person. Treat the percentages in this chapter like Pixar treats story reels — a fast, honest guess to be improved, not a verdict to be obeyed.

Strengths & Weaknesses

STRENGTHS

IMAGINATION

See what doesn't exist yet.

FORESIGHT

Sketch tomorrow's shape.

BOLDNESS

Refuse to bow to convention.

HOPE

Keep imagining.

THE WATCH-LIST

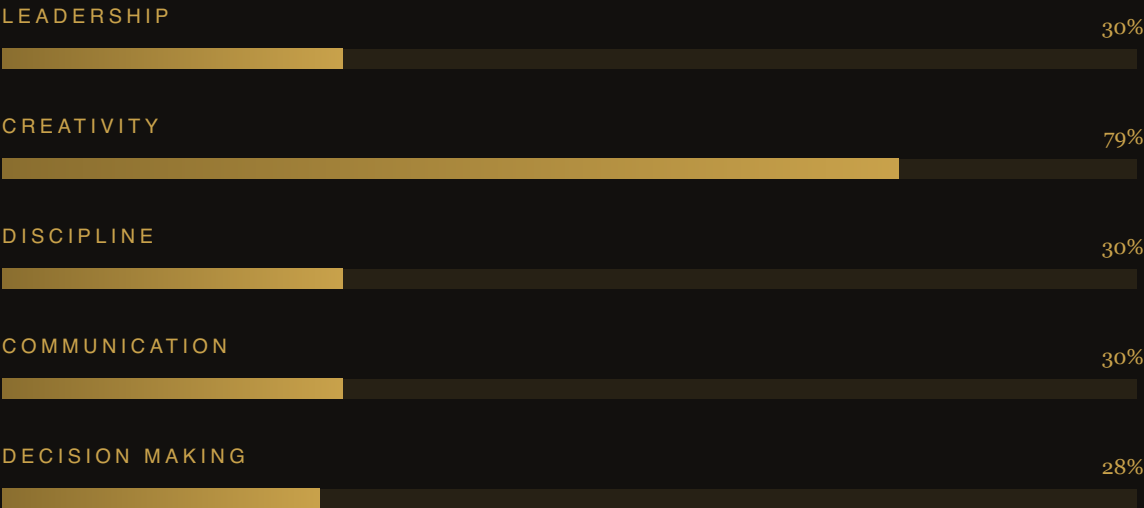
Escapism

Gets so lost sketching tomorrow that today is left to fend for itself.

A shadow is not a flaw list — it is your signature strength with the brakes removed. The watch-list exists because every entry on the left column can become the entry on the right.

Behavioural Facets

Five working modes, scored from the archetype's underlying dimension weights.



The audience reads shape before colour.

Under Pressure & In Study

STRESS BEHAVIOUR

Under pressure, leans hardest on imagination — the same trait that defines them at their best, pushed until it starts to cost something. Recovery comes through naming the cost out loud.

LEARNING STYLE

Learns fastest through foresight in low-stakes repetition, before any public test.

DECISION MAKING

The Visionary decides through imagination first and hope last — reversing that order is the most common self-reported regret of this archetype.

Field notes are directional, not diagnostic — drawn from the archetype model, not from psychology. Use them the way a character designer would: as acting notes.

ARCHETYPE · ON SCREEN · NEW IN 2.0

The Visionary on Screen

Five characters the world already loves, built from your archetype — study what their designers did with it.

SAILOR MOON · SAILOR MOON

Ornament as armour — the design proves that softness and authority are not opposites. Study how visionary-type design choices show up here: the same instinct that defines Visionary shows up as a specific, drawable design choice, not a label stated out loud.

TANJIRO KAMADO · DEMON SLAYER

Armor built from softness, not hardness — a fighter whose design leads with warmth. Study how visionary-type design choices show up here: the same instinct that defines Visionary shows up as a specific, drawable design choice, not a label stated out loud.

TOTORO · MY NEIGHBOR TOTORO · STUDIO GHIBLI

Pure circle shape language — the design commits so fully to softness that it reads as safe instantly. Study how visionary-type design choices show up here: the same instinct that defines Visionary shows up as a specific, drawable design choice, not a label stated out loud.

A pose is personality under gravity.

What Their Designers Knew

These visionary-adjacent designs share one thing: none of them lead with the literal trait name. Imagination is never drawn as a label — it's drawn as a choice about silhouette, palette, or posture that the audience feels before they can name it. That's the brief for your own design too.

THE PATTERN — Survival is never drawn as muscle. It is drawn as evidence: what the character keeps, repairs, refuses to put down. Your symbol — The Unfinished Ascent — is that evidence, pre-designed. The pages ahead tell you where to put it.

Damage is a receipt, not a texture.

ARCHETYPE · ON SCREEN · YOUR OWN MATCHES

Your Visual Discovery Matches

Unlike the five characters on the previous pages, these are the ones your OWN photo actually matched — ranked by design similarity, not archetype.

The pages that follow study each match's real designer: what they built, and how.

One accent, placed, beats five, scattered.

Writing the Wound

Your record already contains the raw material — read it as a psychologist, then draw it as a designer.

THE WOUND

Every Visionary design starts from what was survived. Your realm supplies it: The Mountain Belt, where the mind reaches for the summit. Decide the ONE event your character measures all others against — you never have to draw the event, only its receipts.

THE COMPENSATION

Escapism is the shadow — which means the design should visibly over-express imagination: give it a physical tell the audience can spot before the character speaks a word.

THE SOFT CONTRADICTION

Give the design one element that argues with the wound — something kept, repaired, or worn openly against the character's better judgement, echoing the unfinished ascent. The contradiction is where the audience falls in love.

THE BODY REMEMBERS

Posture is the wound made visible. Write three physical habits that reveal escapism before the story does; draw two of them.

“

A character should be recognisable from
the silhouette of their position — who
they stand beside, and who they stand
against.

PARAPHRASED FROM CHARACTER-DESIGN PRACTICE POPULARISED BY
AKIRA TORIYAMA'S ENSEMBLE WORK

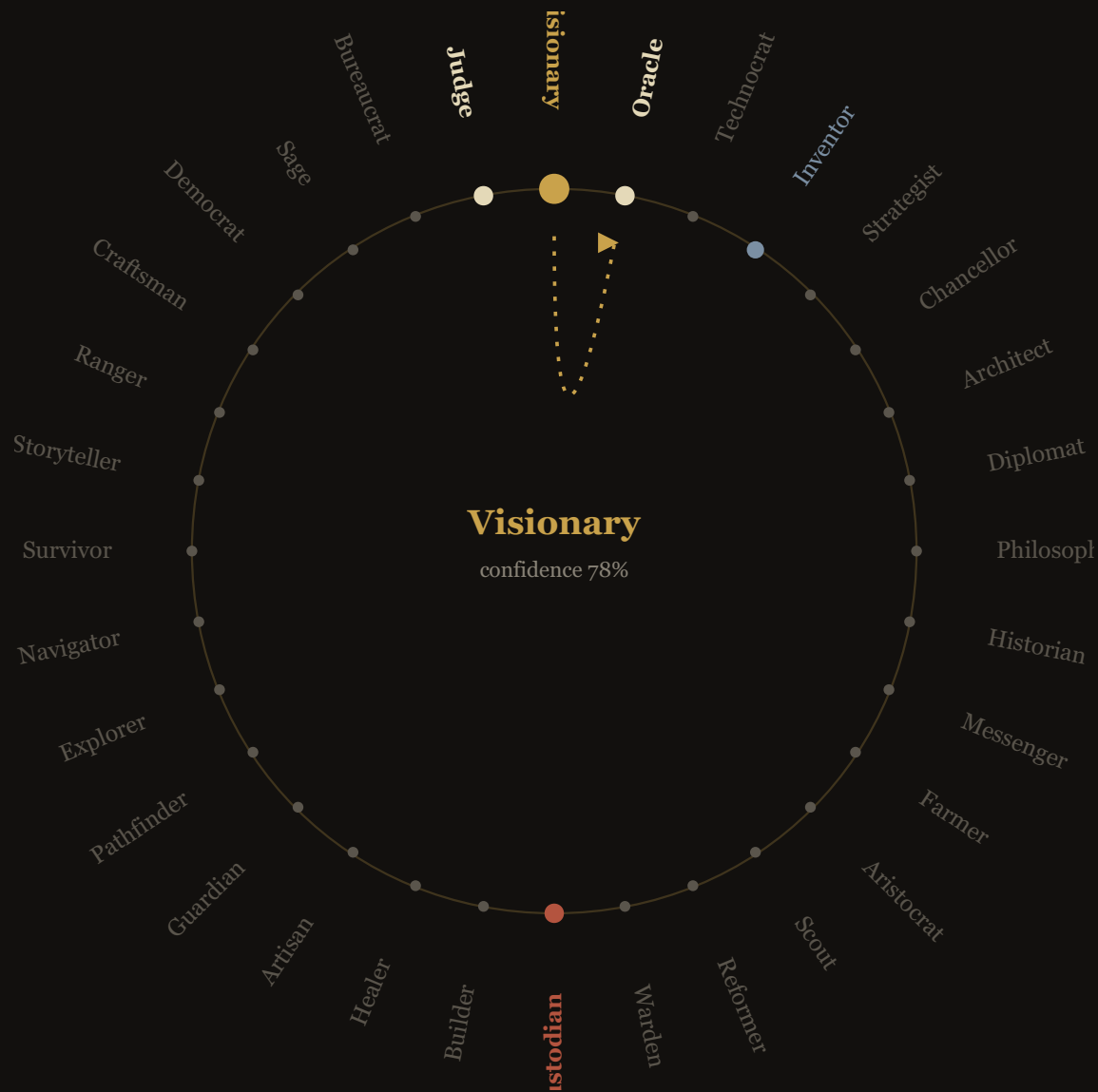
— paraphrased, as labelled

WHY THIS OPENS THE CHAPTER

The Wheel is the Giantverse cast photo. Where you stand on it — your neighbours,
your opposite — is itself a piece of design information, and this chapter teaches you to
read it like a designer.

The Wheel of Thirty-Two

Your position among all thirty-two archetypes. Gold — you. Pale gold — your wheel neighbours. Blue-grey — your Realm. Red — your Opposite. The arrow marks your growth direction.



ARCHETYPE · MAP

Reading Your Position

CURRENT POSITION

Position 1 of 32 — the Visionary (Risō).

NEIGHBOURING ARCHETYPES

Oracle (Yogen) · Judge (Sabaki) — the directions of natural drift as your answers evolve.

COMPATIBLE ARCHETYPES

Oracle · Inventor — fellow travelers of The Mountain Belt.

OPPOSITE

Custodian (Hozon) — not an enemy: the other answer to your shared question.

THE CENTRAL QUESTION

Should we imagine tomorrow, or preserve yesterday?

GROWTH DIRECTION

Toward the Oracle — the neighbour your scores already lean into.

Simplicity is what survives affection.

How This Book Was Computed

Every recommendation in this dossier is traceable to a decision below. No page is arbitrary.

01	BIRTH DATA	Name, day and month seed the syllable tables that mint your Birth Name — deterministic, so your name is a fact, not a roll.
02	IDENTITY	Sixteen questions sampled from a 112-question bank, two per psychological dimension, so no two Hunts ask the same paper.
03	SIGNALS	Every answer becomes a weighted signal across eight dimensions — values, fears, dreams, power, people, decisions, leadership, motivation.
04	ARCHETYPE	Thirty-two archetypes score your signal profile; the leader must clear its own confidence threshold to claim you.
05	WHEEL POSITION	Your archetype's seat fixes neighbours, realm-kin and your opposite — the cast chapter is computed from these adjacencies.
06	REALM	Archetype determines realm bias; realm supplies the materials, textures, and home ground your character is designed from.
07	PSYCHOLOGY	Dimension weights are re-projected as behavioural facets, stress behaviour and the shadow — your strength with the brakes removed.
08	SHAPE LANGUAGE	Trait families map to classical shape theory: endurance and drive to triangles, order to squares, communion to circles.
09	PALETTE	Realm materials set the 70/25 base; your Order's signal colour is reserved as the 5% accent.
10	BLUEPRINT	Every recommendation on the design pages cites one of the layers above — nothing is arbitrary, everything is traceable.

Why the Engine Works This Way

WHY A QUESTION BANK?

A fixed quiz produces fixed answers shared online within a week. Sampling from 112 questions keeps every Hunt personal and every dossier honest.

WHY CONFIDENCE, NOT CERTAINTY?

The engine reports 82%, never 100% — because people are not lookup tables. The remainder is yours to overrule, and the retake exists for exactly that.

WHY A WHEEL AND NOT A LIST?

Adjacency is information: growth is modelled as drift to a neighbour, rivalry as opposition across the circle. Geometry stores psychology.

WHY DOES THE SHADOW GET A PAGE?

Design theory: villains and flaws generate more visual ideas than virtues. The shadow is your strength inverted — which makes it drawable.

THE HONEST FRAME — The engine is a model, and models are arguments, not oracles. Its job is to hand you a defensible starting point and show its working — yours is to overrule it wherever your own evidence is stronger.

PROFESSIONAL SECRET · NO. 2

The audience remembers contrast, not detail.

One sharp value change outlives fifty perfect buckles. Spend your effort
where the eye actually goes.

“

A character is shaped by the world that
raised them, long before the artist
arrives.

PARAPHRASED FROM HAYAO MIYAZAKI'S WRITINGS ON WORLD-BUILDING

— paraphrased, as labelled

WHY THIS OPENS THE CHAPTER

Ghibli films begin with places, not faces: the town teaches you who the character must be. Read your Realm pages the same way — as the childhood your character wears.

The Mountain Belt: Craft & Arms

ARCHITECTURE

Vertical and light-chasing: towers, terraces, and glass built to catch the thin high-altitude sun. Kuryo buildings are proud of how far you can see from them.

WEAPONS

Precision over power — Kuryo arms favour range and accuracy, tools for a people who would rather solve a problem from a distance than wrestle it up close.

SYMBOLS

The unfinished ascent; the telescope aimed higher than it needs to be; the switchback trail drawn as a single continuous line.

WHY THIS MATTERS — The Mountain Belt culture keeps damage legible, so your costume carries visible repairs. Costume becomes biography: every seam is a sentence about a day the character survived.

Negative space is load-bearing.

LORE · HOME REALM

Legends of The Mountain Belt

They speak of the Cartographer of the Last Ridge, who is said to have mapped every visible peak from Kuryo's highest observatory and then, upon finishing, immediately began a second map of the peaks that couldn't yet be seen.

Every child of The Mountain Belt grows up on this story. Whether your character finds it inspiring or exhausting — that choice is character design, and it is yours to make.

Style is a promise kept per panel.

The Record of the Visionarys

The story every Visionary is measured against.

Long before — took the name, generations of Visionarys kept a record of every one of them who answered the call the same way: Sees the shape of what doesn't exist yet; sketches futures vivid enough to pull the world forward. The record is not a list of victories — it is a list of the moment each of them chose, at cost, what a Visionary is for.

CULTURAL NOTE

Visionarys greet each other by naming the trait they're proudest of that week — a small, specific honesty considered more truthful than a formal title.

YOUR SYMBOL

The Unfinished Ascent — The summit is not the point — the climb rewires what you thought was possible.

One day, the record-keepers will tell a story like this about — . The pages that follow — the Hero Journey — are its first draft.

Detail is a spice, not a meal.

“

Not everyone can become a great artist,
but a great artist can come from
anywhere.

WRITTEN BY BRAD BIRD · RATATOUILLE (2007)

WHY THIS OPENS THE CHAPTER

A cast exists to test the hero from every direction — mentor, rival, monster. Bird's line is the test each of your eight companions poses to your character: greatness has no permitted address.

RELATIONSHIPS · THE HERO

The Oracle You Are Becoming

Oracle · Yogen · Order of Giants

THE INTUITION

WHY THEY ARE IN YOUR STORY

Your scores already lean toward the Oracle — the wheel's natural next step from Visionary.

HOW YOU INTERACT

They act where you deliberate, and deliberate where you act; travelling together, each of you covers the other's blind quarter.

THE GROWTH LESSON

Intuition is where imagination goes next — not a departure from it.

Design brief — give this character a silhouette that contrasts yours, one visual element borrowed from your palette, and one they could never wear.

The second read is where love starts.

RELATIONSHIPS · THE HEROINE

The Philosopher of the Crossing Path

Philosopher · Tetsugaku · Order of Giants

THE INQUIRY

WHY THEY ARE IN YOUR STORY

A quarter-turn across the wheel: close enough to understand you, far enough to surprise you.

HOW YOU INTERACT

Where your instinct says “See what doesn't exist yet.”, theirs says “Questions drive truth.” — and the story lives in the negotiation.

THE GROWTH LESSON

Inquiry — the strength you respect most because it costs you the most to practise.

Design brief — give this character a silhouette that contrasts yours, one visual element borrowed from your palette, and one they could never wear.

Draw ten cheap ideas before one dear one.

RELATIONSHIPS · THE MENTOR

The Elder Oracle of The Mountain Belt

Oracle · Yogen · Order of Giants

THE INTUITION

WHY THEY ARE IN YOUR STORY

Your own Realm, seen further down the path — proof your home ground can be answered a different way.

HOW YOU INTERACT

They will not correct your path; they will show you the map of theirs and let the difference teach.

THE GROWTH LESSON

“I will speak the pattern I see, even when no one wants to hear it yet.” — a promise you were never asked to make, kept by someone who shares your ground.

Design brief — give this character a silhouette that contrasts yours, one visual element borrowed from your palette, and one they could never wear.

Proportion is the first joke and the last law.

RELATIONSHIPS · THE RIVAL

The Custodian Across the Wheel

Custodian · Hozon · Order of Giants

THE STEWARDSHIP

WHY THEY ARE IN YOUR STORY

You answer the same question differently: Should we imagine tomorrow, or preserve yesterday?

HOW YOU INTERACT

Every plan you make, they counter — not from malice, but from a whole life of the other answer. Beating them requires understanding them.

THE GROWTH LESSON

The day you can argue their answer at full strength is the day your own answer becomes earned instead of inherited.

Design brief — give this character a silhouette that contrasts yours, one visual element borrowed from your palette, and one they could never wear.

An outline should gossip about its owner.

RELATIONSHIPS · THE ALLY

The Judge at Your Shoulder

Judge · Sabaki · Order of Giants

THE FAIRNESS

WHY THEY ARE IN YOUR STORY

Your other wheel-neighbour — near enough to trust on sight, different enough to be useful.

HOW YOU INTERACT

No speeches, no ceremony: they simply appear where you need a second pair of hands, already working.

THE GROWTH LESSON

Fairness — offered so casually you'll almost miss that it's a discipline.

Design brief — give this character a silhouette that contrasts yours, one visual element borrowed from your palette, and one they could never wear.

Colour is temperature; temperature is intent.

RELATIONSHIPS · THE MONSTER

The Beast of Escapism

A figure beyond the wheel



WHY THEY ARE IN YOUR STORY

Every archetype's shadow, loosed into the world, takes a shape. Yours is escapism, made vast, made hungry.

HOW YOU INTERACT

Gets so lost sketching tomorrow that today is left to fend for itself. As a creature, it does this to whole villages at a time.

THE GROWTH LESSON

It cannot be slain by your strength — your strength is what feeds it. It is starved by the thing you find hardest.

Design brief — give this character a silhouette that contrasts yours, one visual element borrowed from your palette, and one they could never wear.

Nothing on the belt without a story in the bag.

RELATIONSHIPS · THE VILLAIN

The Fallen Custodian

Custodian · Hozon · Order of Giants

THE STAGNATION

WHY THEY ARE IN YOUR STORY

Not your opposite — your opposite's shadow, with an army and a grievance.

HOW YOU INTERACT

Guards the tradition so fiercely that nothing — not even necessary growth — is allowed through. They believe, sincerely, that this is the only answer left to the question you both carry.

THE GROWTH LESSON

They are what your Rival becomes without you — which means your Rival is what they could have been with you.

Design brief — give this character a silhouette that contrasts yours, one visual element borrowed from your palette, and one they could never wear.

The fill test forgives nothing and lies never.

RELATIONSHIPS · THE SHADOW SELF

The Visionary, Unchecked

Visionary · Risō · Giants

THE THE UNFINISHED ASCENT

WHY THEY ARE IN YOUR STORY

Escapism: your own signature strength, imagination, taken to the extreme where it stops serving anyone.

HOW YOU INTERACT

Gets so lost sketching tomorrow that today is left to fend for itself.

THE GROWTH LESSON

The shadow is not defeated once. It is out-practised daily — usually by borrowing one habit from your Opposite.

Design brief — give this character a silhouette that contrasts yours, one visual element borrowed from your palette, and one they could never wear.

Squares endure. Circles welcome. Triangles warn.

PROFESSIONAL SECRET · NO. 3

Every accessory should be earned.

If you cannot say where the character got it, the audience cannot feel why
they keep it.

“

You do not draw a character. You draw a
life that happens to be visible.

PARAPHRASED FROM GLEN KEANE'S ANIMATION LECTURES

— paraphrased, as labelled

WHY THIS OPENS THE CHAPTER

Keane animated Ariel and the Beast by acting the feeling before drawing the line. Your Hero Journey chapter is that feeling written down — act it before you draw a single pose.

HERO JOURNEY · BEAT 4 OF 7

The Hidden Strength

Beneath the Visionary runs a quieter current of the Oracle:
intuition, surfacing exactly when the primary path fails.
Enemies who prepare for a Visionary are never prepared for
that.

Your character's silence should be drawable.

HERO JOURNEY · BEAT 5 OF 7

The Greatest Trial

The Hunt will force the question the wheel has always asked of them — and their answer will pull them toward the Oracle's path or harden them against it. The trial is not the Giant. The trial is choosing, at full cost, in front of everyone, what a Visionary is for.

Costume seams are the body's punctuation.

HERO JOURNEY · BEAT 6 OF 7

The Transformation

They enter the Hunt a Visionary and leave something the wheel has no single name for: a Visionary who has learned the Oracle's craft without surrendering their own imagination. The shadow of escapism does not vanish — it is finally, daily, out-practised.

What they refuse to wear is also design.

HERO JOURNEY · BEAT 7 OF 7

The Final Destiny

A place among the Giants' honoured names — the Visionary
whose path becomes a route others can walk, whose
imagination outlives the Hunt that demanded it.

Hair is shape first, strands never.

“

Quality is the best business plan.

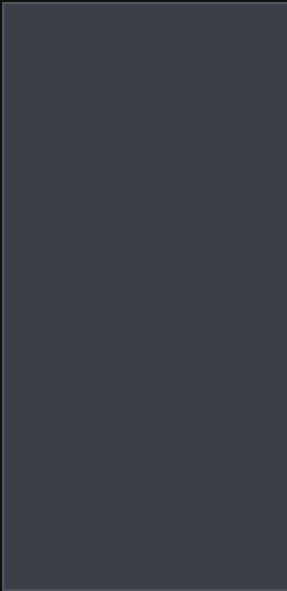
JOHN LASSETER

WHY THIS OPENS THE CHAPTER

The Blueprint chapter converts everything known about you into professional design decisions. Quality here means fit — every recommendation earns its place by matching who the record says you are.

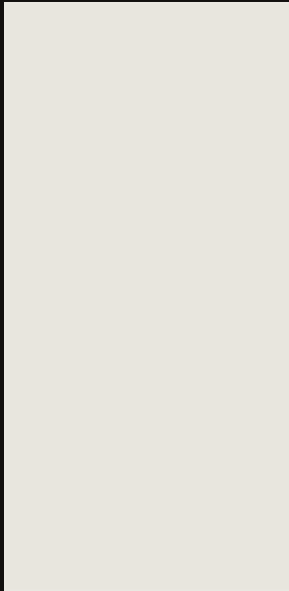
Colour Palette

The Mountain Belt materials with the Ascent Seal accent. Keep the accent under ten percent of the design — it should be findable, not loud.



Summit Slate
#3B4048

Primary — garments, base tone



Thin-Air White
#E8E6DE

Secondary — light layers, trim



Glacier Blue
#6E8FA3

Support — accessories, shadow tones



Ascent Seal
#D98E3B

Accent — Order insignia, eyes of the design

Print note — these values are screen hexes; when working in markers or paint, match by eye against the printed chips above rather than the numbers.

Hands sell what faces oversell.

BLUEPRINT · HEAD

Face, Eyes & Hair

FACE & EYES

Let the eyes carry imagination — the archetype's defining trait should be legible in the default expression, not just the costume.

HAIR

Shape family follows the circle — soft, rounded masses, kept simple enough to read at thumbnail size.

PERSONALITY EXPRESSION

Default expression carries imagination; the 'tell' — the micro-expression under stress — should hint at escapism without stating it.

A character's shadow belongs in the acting long before it enters the plot.

The villain is the hero's habit, unsupervised.

Costume, Accessories & Arms

COSTUME

Base layers in The Mountain Belt materials (see palette), cut in circle-family blocks; one field layer carrying the Order of Giants sigil at chest or shoulder.

ACCESSORIES

A worn, personal token referencing “The Unfinished Ascent” — small enough for close-ups, distinctive enough for merchandise.

WEAPON / TOOL

Whatever best expresses imagination in use — function first, ornament second.

TEXTURES

Let the surface show the Order: ceremonial finish and clean seams, consistent with how a Visionary actually lives.

Motion & Acting

MOTION STYLE

Grounded holds, deliberate transitions; anticipation poses should express imagination kinetically, not just visually.

WHY

Animation and pose sheets should express the archetype's defining trait physically, not just through costume or face.

When you reach the pose sheets in the workbook, act these notes out physically before drawing them — five seconds of standing the way your character stands teaches more than an hour of reference-hunting.

Draw the wound where the eye lands second.

PROFESSIONAL SECRET · NO. 4

Rendering never fixes weak design.

Polish is a multiplier. Multiply a weak idea and you get a shinier weak idea.

“

Every artist has thousands of bad drawings in them, and the only way to get rid of them is to draw them out.

CHUCK JONES · WARNER BROS., LOONEY TUNES

WHY THIS OPENS THE CHAPTER

Nine lessons follow. None of them will make your first drawing good — they will make your hundredth drawing extraordinary. Jones is telling you the price, and promising it is payable.

MASTERCLASS · LESSON 1 OF 9

What Character Design Actually Is

Character design is decision-making made visible — not rendering skill.

THE JOB

A character design answers three questions at a glance: who is this, what do they want, and what will they do to get it. Every line either supports one of those answers or dilutes it.

READ ORDER

Viewers read silhouette first, colour second, face third, details last. Budget your effort in exactly that order — a perfect eye on a mushy silhouette is wasted work.

THE ONE-SENTENCE TEST

Before drawing, write your character in one sentence including a contradiction: 'a gentle giant terrified of breaking things.' Contradiction is what makes a design feel alive rather than assembled.

ITERATION

Professionals draw ten cheap thumbnails before one expensive drawing. Quantity first, quality second — the good design is usually hiding around thumbnail seven.

A silhouette is a signature you can shout.

Anime Construction Basics

Anime style is a construction method, not a shortcut.

HEAD FIRST

The head unit measures everything: standard anime bodies run 6–7.5 heads tall. Pick your head count and hold it on every sheet — inconsistency here is the most common beginner tell.

THE CRANIUM + JAW

Build the head as a ball (cranium) plus a wedge (jaw). The eye-line sits lower than realism — roughly halfway or below — leaving the large forehead the style expects.

EYES AS DESIGN OBJECTS

Anime eyes are designed shapes, not anatomy. Decide your character's eye shape (frame, iris size, highlight count) once, on the eye sheet, then treat it as a logo: reproduce, don't reinvent.

LINE ECONOMY

The style's power is selective detail: dense information at face, hands and costume focal points; near-empty simplicity everywhere else. If everything is detailed, nothing is.

Shape Language

Circles feel friendly, squares feel reliable, triangles feel dangerous — audiences know this before they know they know it.

THE THREE FAMILIES

Circle: approachable, soft, trustworthy. Square: stable, strong, stubborn. Triangle: fast, sharp, threatening. Every memorable character leads with one family and seasons with a second.

WHERE IT LIVES

Shape language operates at every scale — overall silhouette, costume blocks, hair masses, even eyebrow angles. Consistency across scales is what makes a design feel inevitable.

CONTRAST FOR CAST

Give allies contrasting shape families so group shots read instantly. Your dossier's companion pages specify contrasts for exactly this reason.

BREAKING THE RULE

A round-shaped villain or triangular healer is a deliberate, powerful choice — but only reads as deliberate if the rest of the design is disciplined.

Every belt earns rent or moves out.

Silhouette

If the design works filled with solid black, it works.

THE FILL TEST

Flood your character with black. Can you still tell who it is, what they carry, and what they're feeling? That's the whole test, and professionals run it on every pass.

POCKETS OF SKY

Strong silhouettes trap negative space — the gap inside a bent elbow, between blade and hip. These 'pockets of sky' are what make an outline legible at thumbnail size.

THE BIG-MEDIUM-SMALL RULE

Divide the silhouette into one big mass, one medium, one small. Equal-sized masses read as noise; the 60/30/10 rhythm reads as design.

SIGNATURE BREAK

Give the outline one element that breaks its overall flow — a trailing sash, an asymmetric shoulder, your symbol worn large. That break is what fan artists will draw first.

The brow is the loudest muscle.

MASTERCLASS · LESSON 5 OF 9

Costume Design

Costume is biography you can draw.

FUNCTION FIRST

Every costume element should answer 'why do they wear this?' — climate, work, rank, memory. Your realm's lore pages list the materials; use them as your fabric store.

LAYER LOGIC

Build in layers with a story: base layer (climate), work layer (calling), status layer (order/rank), personal layer (the keepsake). A costume with layer logic survives redesigns and spin-offs.

WEAR AND TEAR

Decide where the costume is worn, patched or stained. Damage placement tells the audience how this body moves and what it has survived — cheaper than a backstory page.

THE 70/25/5 PALETTE

Dominant colour 70%, secondary 25%, accent 5%. Your dossier palette page is pre-mixed to this ratio — the accent is your Order colour.

Draw weight, and balance arrives free.

MASTERCLASS · LESSON 6 OF 9

Colour Theory for Characters

Colour is emotional shorthand — spend it deliberately.

VALUE BEFORE HUE

Convert to greyscale: if the design muddies, no hue choice will save it. Aim for three clearly separated value zones before choosing a single colour.

TEMPERATURE TELLS

Warm colours advance and invite; cool colours recede and compose. A cool character with one warm element (eyes, a scarf, a scar) directs attention exactly where you want it.

SATURATION DISCIPLINE

Full saturation everywhere exhausts the eye. Keep large areas muted and let small areas sing — your 5% accent should be the most saturated note in the design.

COLOUR SCRIPTING

Plan how the palette shifts with story mood: the same character at their darkest hour, desaturated; at triumph, accent blazing. One palette, scripted, beats five palettes.

Reference is a ladder, not a chair.

MASTERCLASS · LESSON 7 OF 9

Expression Design

A character who can only make one face is a statue.

THE CORE SIX

Master your character's joy, anger, sorrow, fear, surprise and disgust before inventing subtle blends. The expression sheet in your workbook is laid out for exactly these.

ASYMMETRY IS LIFE

Real expressions are asymmetric — one brow leads, one mouth corner wins. Perfectly mirrored faces read as masks.

THE CHARACTER FILTER

Run every emotion through personality: how does THIS character do anger — loud, cold, smiling? Your archetype's field notes (stress behaviour) are the acting reference.

EYEBROWS DO THE WORK

In anime construction, brows and upper lids carry most of the emotional signal. When an expression isn't landing, fix the brows before touching anything else.

Exaggeration is honesty at volume.

MASTERCLASS · LESSON 8 OF 9

Pose Design

Pose is personality under gravity.

LINE OF ACTION

Every pose starts as a single curved line — the spine of the idea. Draw it first, then hang the body on it. Poses built limb-by-limb read stiff no matter how well rendered.

WEIGHT AND BALANCE

Decide where the mass sits: a guardian plants weight through both heels; a scout floats it on the balls of the feet. Your blueprint's motion notes specify your character's default.

SILHOUETTE AGAIN

Run the fill test on every pose. Clear poses keep limbs off the torso's mass and trap negative space. If elbows vanish into ribs, rotate the pose, don't render harder.

STORY POSES

Beyond action: design a waiting pose, a losing pose, a lying pose. The quiet poses are where personality actually lives — and where judges look for it.

The memorable is the removable, kept.

MASTERCLASS · LESSON 9 OF 9

Professional Workflow

How working designers get from blank page to final sheet.

THUMBNAILS (10+)

Tiny, fast, fearless. No erasing, no faces, silhouette only. You are shopping for an idea, not making a drawing.

CONSTRUCTION PASS

Take the winning thumbnail to full size in simple volumes — head unit, ribcage, pelvis, limb cylinders. Fix proportion here; it is ten times cheaper than fixing it in line.

DESIGN PASS

Costume blocks, hair masses, props — still no detail. Run the fill test and the 70/25/5 palette in flats.

FINAL LINE & PRESENTATION

Clean line weight (thicker outside, thinner inside), flat colour, minimal shading. Present on the turnaround sheet: front, side, back, same head count, same ground line. This is the format the Giant Hunt expects.

Two shapes agree; three shapes argue.

DESIGN LIKE... · STUDIO GHIBLI

Design Like Studio Ghibli

Character serves world; stillness is content.

MA — THE PAUSE

Ghibli protects 'ma': beats where nothing happens so the audience can feel. Design translation — give your character one restful pose and one prop that only matters when they are still.

ORDINARY FIRST

Ghibli heroes look like people before they look like heroes; wonder lands harder from a believable base. Keep one boring, functional garment in your design.

NATURE HAS AGENCY

Environments act on characters — wind, rain, mud are co-stars. Your realm's weather should be visible somewhere on the costume.

FOR YOUR SHEET — For your character: draw the waiting pose from the workbook FIRST, before any action pose. If the design is boring at rest, Ghibli would send it back.

Philosophy, never imitation — these pages teach how a studio thinks, not how it renders.

Give the eye a path or it leaves.

DESIGN LIKE... · SPIDER-VERSE

Design Like Spider-Verse

Style is identity — every character keeps their native visual language.

ONE WORLD, MANY GRAMMARS

Each Spider-person is rendered in their own idiom — anime cel, noir print, picture-book. The film proves styles can share a frame if each is disciplined internally.

FRAME-RATE AS CHARACTER

Miles animates on twos while mentors move on ones — literally out of step until he masters his powers. Motion style is characterisation.

GRAPHIC HONESTY

Halftones, chromatic offsets, hand-drawn effects — the film shows its materials. Let your linework admit it was drawn by a hand.

FOR YOUR SHEET — Choose ONE stylistic signature for your sheet — a line quality, a texture, a printing flaw — and apply it with total consistency. One accent of style, like one accent of colour.

Philosophy, never imitation — these pages teach how a studio thinks, not how it renders.

A prop at rest tells the longest story.

DESIGN LIKE... · ARCANÉ

Design Like Arcane

Painterly surfaces over brutal clarity of shape.

PAINT ON STRUCTURE

Arcane looks hand-painted, but under the brushwork the silhouettes are ruthless — every character passes the fill test before a single stroke lands.

TWO CITIES, TWO PALETTES

Piltover gleams gold-and-blue; Zaun glows toxic green. Faction palette does half the storytelling before dialogue starts. Your Order and Realm are your two cities.

DAMAGE TELLS TIME

Characters age in scars, hair changes and patched gear across acts. Design your character with one 'act two' variant in mind — what breaks, what gets repaired.

FOR YOUR SHEET — Draw your turnaround clean, then produce one 'after the battle' pass: same silhouette, new damage. If the damage placement feels arbitrary, your costume logic needs work.

Philosophy, never imitation — these pages teach how a studio thinks, not how it renders.

Design the tell before the smile.

DESIGN LIKE... · PIXAR

Design Like Pixar

Simplify until only the story remains.

SHAPE THESIS

Every Pixar lead reduces to a sentence of geometry: Carl is a square (stubborn), Russell an egg (unformed), EVE an ellipse (perfect, sealed). Write your character's geometry sentence.

APPEAL ≠ PRETTY

Appeal means the eye wants to keep looking. Asymmetry, imperfection and specificity generate appeal faster than beauty does.

RESEARCH OBSESSION

Pixar sends artists to depths and deserts before designing a fish or a car. Your research field is this dossier — realm materials, archetype acting notes.

FOR YOUR SHEET — Write the geometry sentence for your character in the margin of the blueprint page — subject, dominant shape, contradiction. If you cannot write it, you are not ready to draw it.

Philosophy, never imitation — these pages teach how a studio thinks, not how it renders.

Consistency is what turns marks into style.

INDUSTRY BREAKDOWN

How an Anime Character Reaches the Screen

The pipeline behind every anime character sheet — and why your workbook mirrors it.

CONCEPT / MANGA SOURCE

A designer or mangaka fixes the identity: silhouette, palette, signature break.

SETTEI — THE MODEL SHEET

Turnarounds, expression sheets, hand studies at fixed head-counts — the exact sheets in your workbook. Hundreds of animators must draw the character identically; settei is the contract.

KEY ANIMATION

Genga artists act the character in poses; the design's shape language dictates how they move.

COLOUR DESIGN

A dedicated iro-shitei artist locks palette per lighting situation — day, dusk, battle.

THE LESSON — Nothing in professional animation is drawn twice from imagination — it is drawn once with intent, then reproduced with discipline. Your turnaround sheet is you signing that contract with yourself.

The ground line is the first anatomy.

INDUSTRY BREAKDOWN

How Pixar Builds a Character

From research trip to render farm — the longest character pipeline in the industry.

STORY FIRST

No design exists until the character has a want, a flaw and an arc. Design begins as writing.

RESEARCH & SIMPLIFY

Field research, then reduction: hundreds of sketches distilled to one geometry thesis.

SCULPT & TEST

Maquettes and digital sculpts are lit, posed and 'acted' before approval — the fill test in three dimensions.

SIMULATION BUDGET

Every costume element costs simulation time, so each must justify itself — the industrial version of 'every accessory is earned'.

THE LESSON — Pixar's real secret is sequencing: psychology before geometry, geometry before costume, costume before polish. This dossier is arranged in exactly that order on purpose.

Draw the childhood; the posture follows.

INDUSTRY BREAKDOWN

How Riot Designs a Champion

Character design under the hardest constraint set in the business: readable at 1cm tall, in a crowd, in 0.2 seconds.

THE FANTASY STATEMENT

One sentence of promise — 'the blade that refuses to die' — approved before any art.

SILHOUETTE GATES

Concepts are reviewed as black shapes at gameplay camera distance. Fail the gate, restart — rendering is not permitted to rescue a shape.

COLOUR FOR TEAMFIGHTS

One dominant hue plus one accent, testable against thirty effects exploding at once. The 70/25/5 rule under live fire.

KIT COHERENCE

The character's abilities must be legible from the design — a hook needs a visible hook. Form promises function.

THE LESSON — Constraint is the best design teacher you can hire for free. Draw your character at 3cm tall as a final exam — whatever survives is the actual design.

An empty pocket is wasted lore.

PROFESSIONAL SECRET · NO. 5

Design emotion before beauty.

Beautiful and forgettable ship together constantly. Felt and imperfect is the
rarer cargo.

“

There is no shortcut hiding behind
talent — the hand learns by repetition
what the eye already knows.

PARAPHRASED FROM YUSUKE MURATA'S INTERVIEWS ON PRACTICE

— paraphrased, as labelled

WHY THIS OPENS THE CHAPTER

Murata redrew One-Punch Man chapters he had already finished, for free, because the hand could do better. These worksheets are your version of that discipline — cheap paper, honest reps.

Seven Drills Before the Sheets

Run this ladder once on scrap paper before the formal worksheets. Each rung removes a crutch — what survives all seven is your actual design.

1 · CIRCLES ONLY

Draw your character using nothing but circles. — Forces you to find the design's softness — even a triangle-lead character has circle moments, and now you know where they live.

2 · TRIANGLES ONLY

Redraw the same pose using nothing but triangles. — The opposite pressure. Between these two extremes, your actual shape mix reveals itself.

3 · STRIP THE GEAR

Redraw with every accessory removed. — If the character disappears without their props, the design is a costume rack. The body language must carry identity on its own.

4 · SILHOUETTE ONLY

Fill the figure with solid black. No interior lines. — The professional gate. If this fails, return to step one — nothing after this step can save a failed fill.

5 · FROM MEMORY

Close the book. Draw the character without reference. — Whatever you remembered is the design. Whatever you forgot was noise — consider deleting it.

6 · EXAGGERATE 150%

Push every proportion past comfort: longer, sharper, heavier. — Timid designs die in crowds. You can always retreat from too far; you cannot rescue too safe.

7 · SIMPLIFY TO TEN LINES

Draw the character in ten strokes or fewer. — The final compression. What survives ten lines is your character's true signature — protect it in every future drawing.

Big, medium, small — then stop.

Symmetry over the centre line; weight even
through both feet.

Front View

1

1 head unit

2

3

4

5

6

ground line

FRONT VIEW

Side View

Same head count, same ground line. Check
the ear sits behind the centre of the skull;
spine curves in a soft S.

1

1 head unit

2

3

4

5

6

ground line

SIDE VIEW

Back View

The forgotten view judges love to check. Hair mass, costume back, and how the silhouette reads without a face.

1

1 head unit

2

3

4

5

6

ground line

BACK VIEW

All four angles on one sheet, features aligned across the guide rows. This is the Giant Hunt's expected presentation format.

Head Construction Grid

Cranium ball + jaw wedge at three angles.
Keep the eye line consistent — it's the anchor
for everything else.

eye line FRONT	eye line SIDE	eye line 3 / 4
--------------------------------------	-------------------------------------	--------------------------------------

Eye Sheet

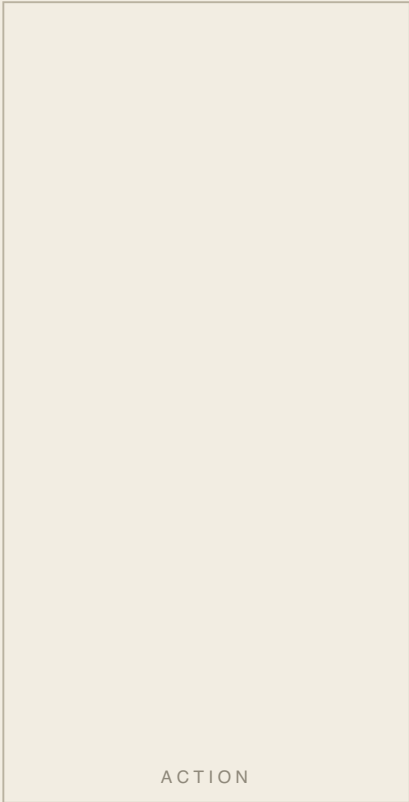
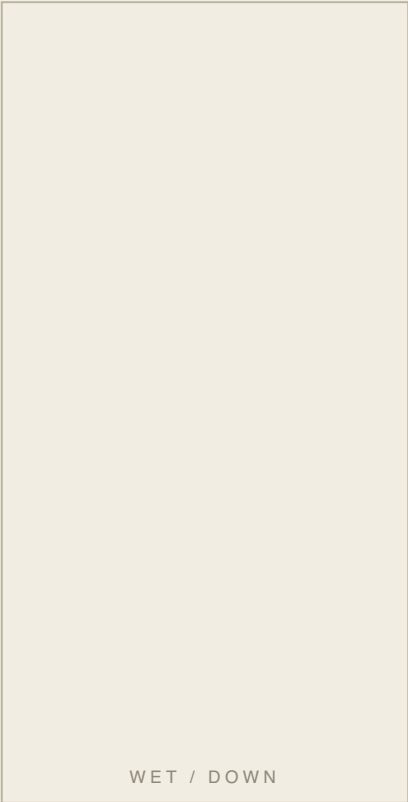
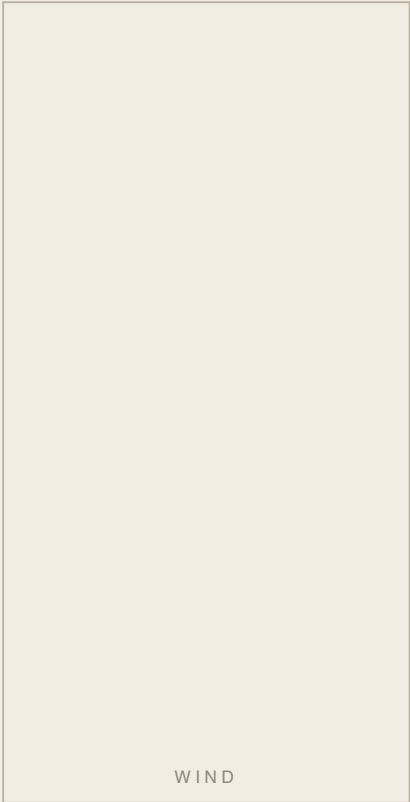
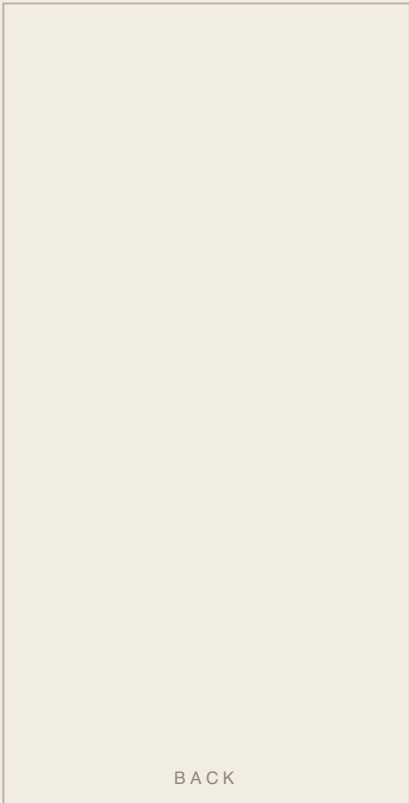
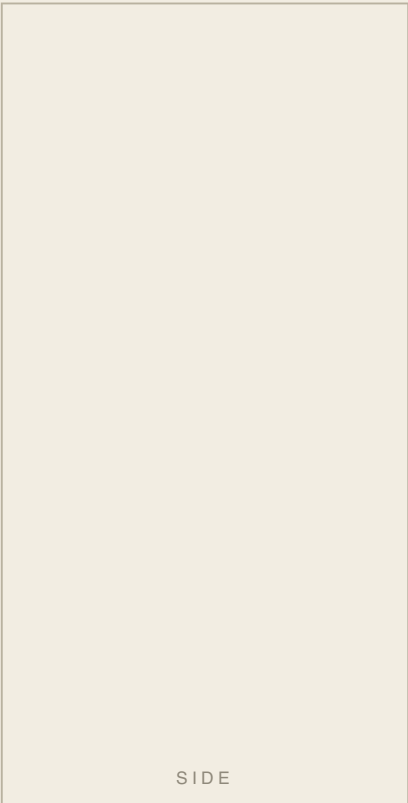
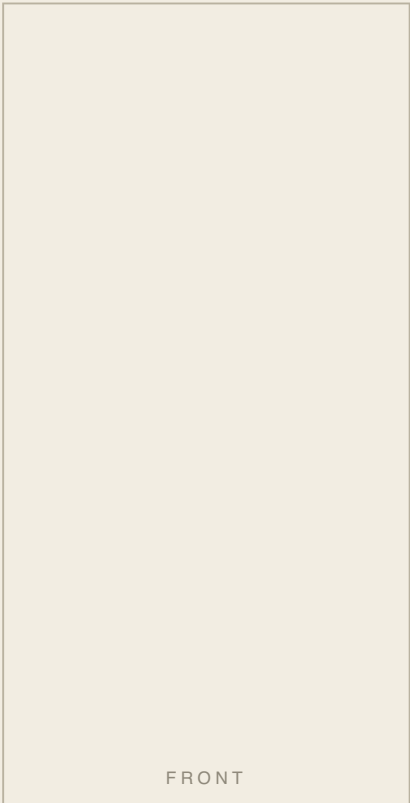
Design the eye once, like a logo: shape, iris size, highlight count. Then repeat until your hand knows it.

Expression Sheet

JOY	ANGER	SORROW
FEAR	SURPRISE	DISGUST
SIGNATURE 1	SIGNATURE 2	AT REST

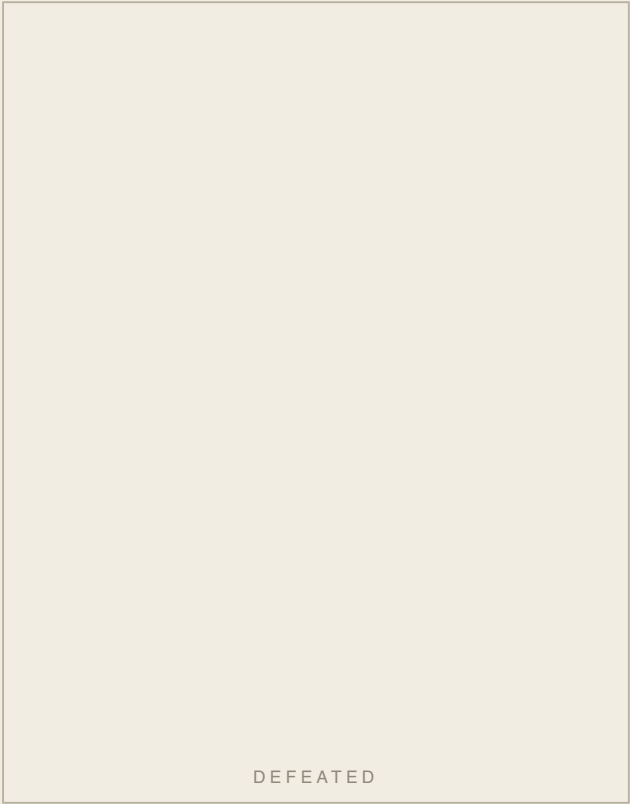
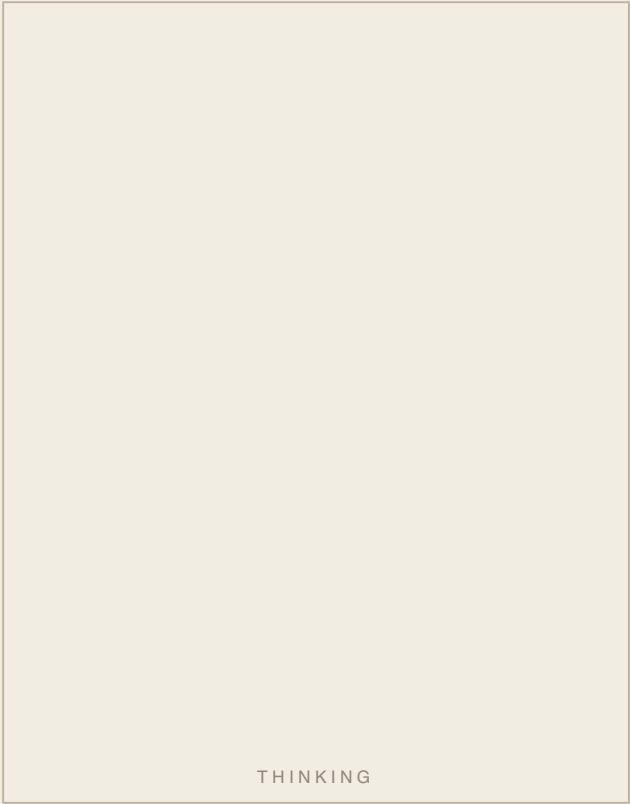
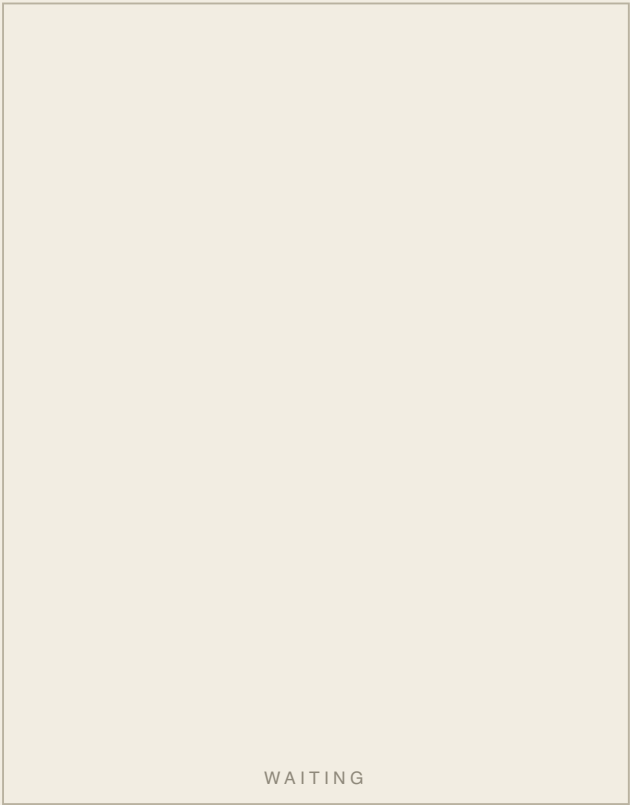
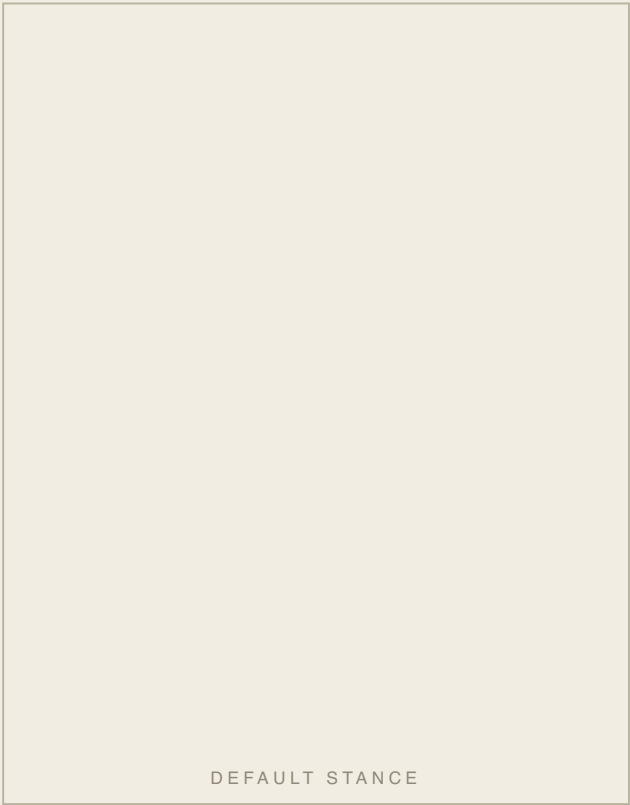
Hair Sheet

Hair as 2–3 large masses, not strands.
Explore front, side and motion states.



Pose Sheet

Quiet poses: standing, waiting, thinking,
losing. Line of action first — one curve, then
the body.



Action Pose

One full-sheet action pose. Push the line of action 20% further than feels safe — paper is cheap.

1

1 head unit

2

3

4

5

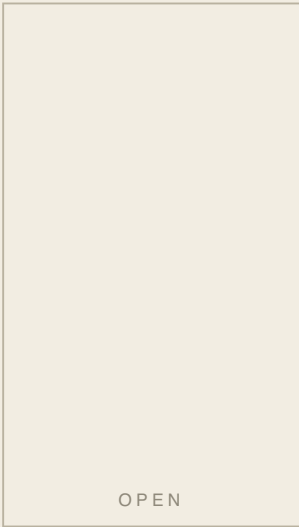
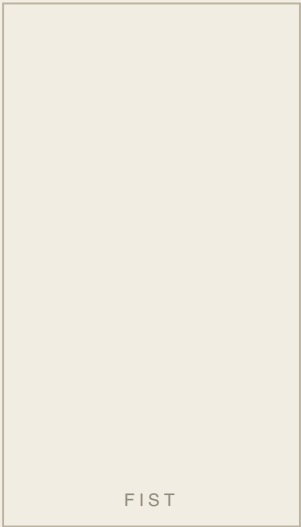
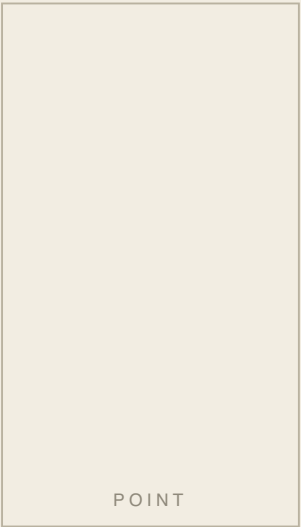
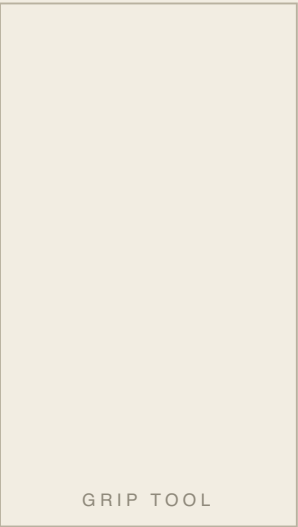
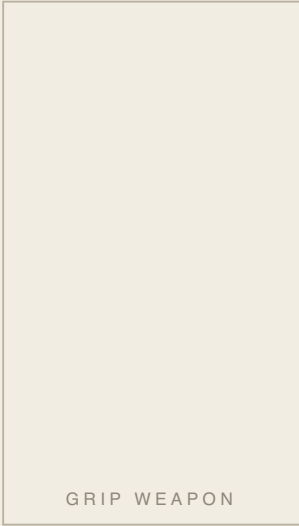
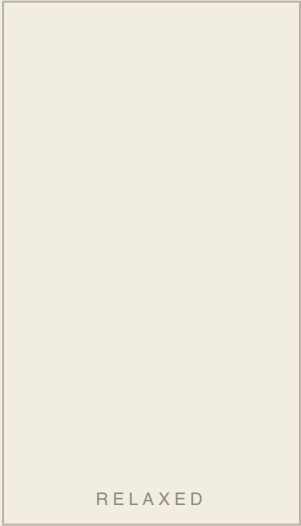
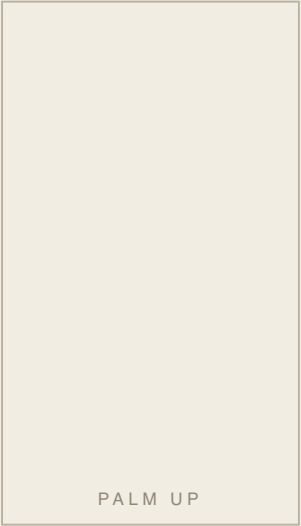
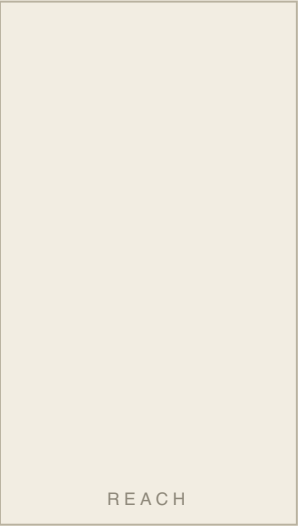
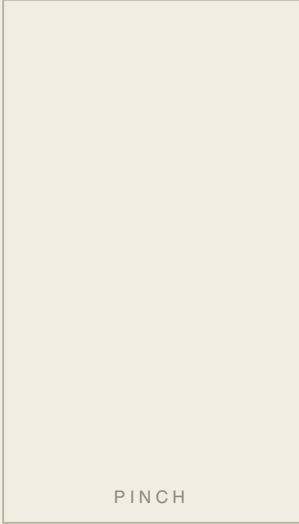
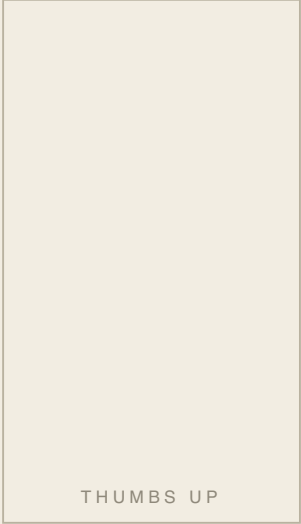
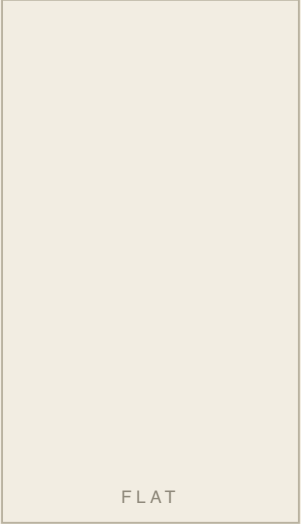
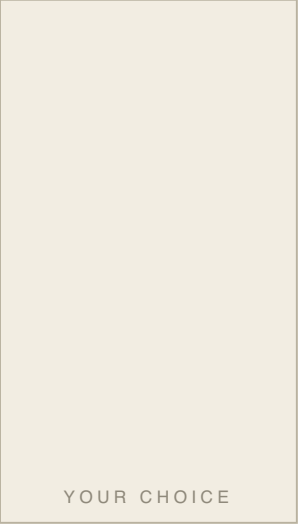
6

ground line

ACTION POSE

Hand Sheet

Mitten-block first, fingers second. Hands sell effort — practise the grips your weapon needs.

 OPEN	 FIST	 POINT	 GRIP TOOL
 GRIP WEAPON	 RELAXED	 PALM UP	 REACH
 PINCH	 THUMBS UP	 FLAT	 YOUR CHOICE

Costume Sheet

1

1 head unit

2

3

4

5

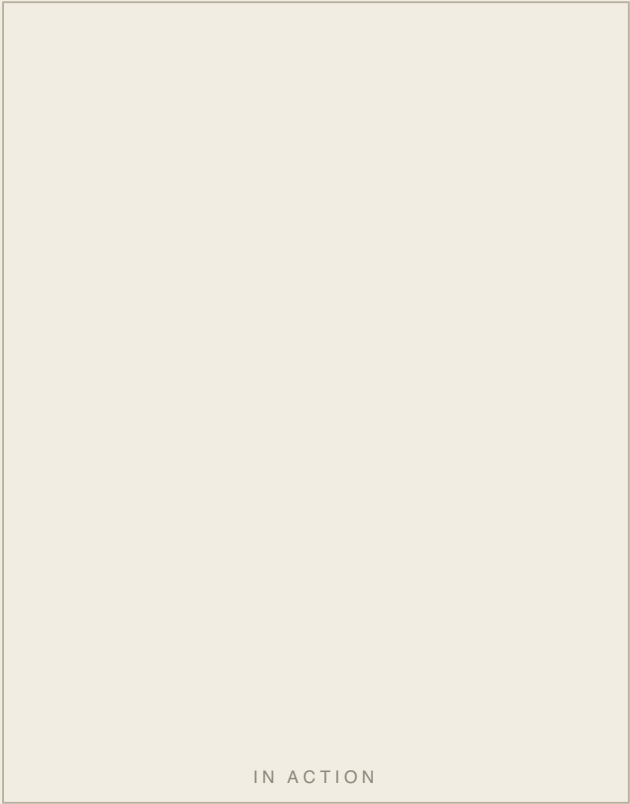
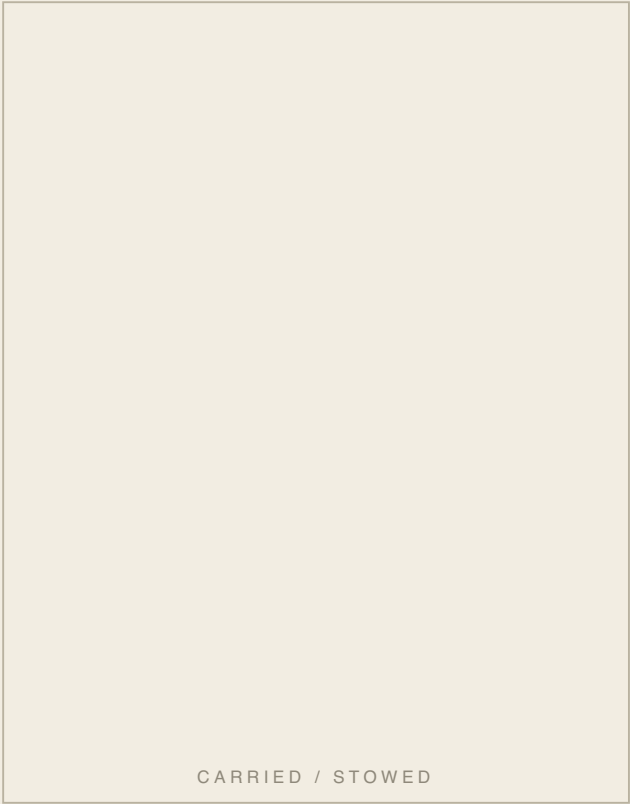
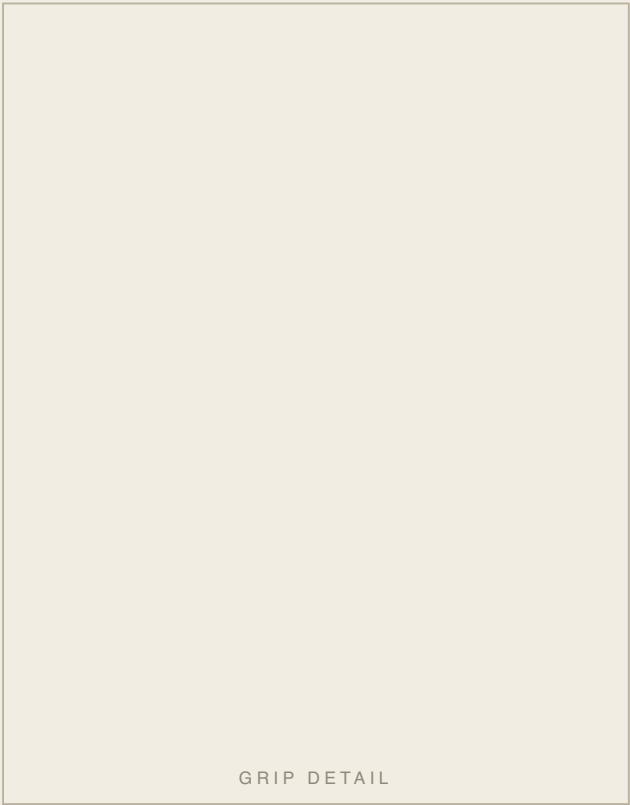
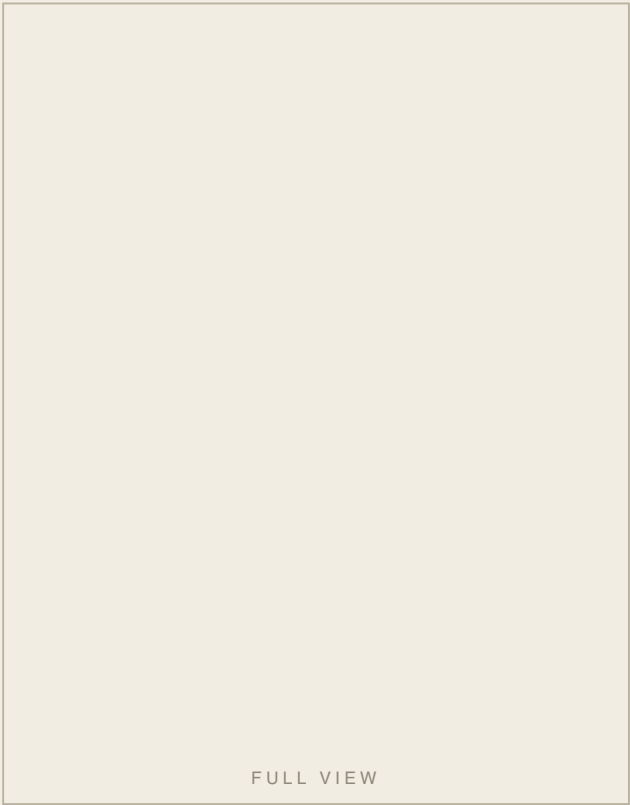
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ground line

COSTUME STUDY

Weapon / Tool Sheet

Draw it as a used object: wear at the grip,
maintenance marks, how it's carried when
NOT in use.



PROFESSIONAL SECRET · NO. 6

The quiet poses are where
personality lives.

Anyone can pose a punch. Judges look at how your character waits.

“

Animation offers a medium of
storytelling and visual entertainment
which can bring pleasure and
information to people of all ages
everywhere in the world.

WALT DISNEY

WHY THIS OPENS THE CHAPTER

The Giant Hunt ends with your drawing joining thousands of others — a world-record cast of original characters. This chapter is the practical bridge from your desk to that record.

Submission Guidelines

WHAT TO SUBMIT

One hand-drawn character design of your Giantverse identity — traditional or digital, drawn by you. AI-generated artwork is not eligible; this dossier deliberately contains recommendations, never images, for that reason.

FORMAT

A clear photograph or scan of your artwork. Include your Giantverse ID and Legacy Name exactly as printed on your Identity Record page.

ORIGINALITY

The design must be your own work, created for the Hunt. Reference is encouraged; tracing and copying are not.

ONE IDENTITY, ONE ENTRY

Each Giantverse identity submits once. Iterate privately on the worksheets — submit only your best turnaround.

Full and current terms are published on the official Giant Hunt submission portal; where this page and the portal differ, the portal governs.

Timeline & Judging

PHASE 1	Identity discovery — complete (you are holding the proof)
PHASE 2	Design window — worksheets, iterations, final turnaround
PHASE 3	Submission window — upload via the official portal
PHASE 4	Verification & record attempt — see next page
PHASE 5	Judging, gallery & honours

JUDGING CRITERIA

Silhouette clarity, shape-language discipline, palette control, costume logic, and — weighted heaviest — how convincingly the design expresses the identity in this dossier. Judges receive your archetype, not your name.

WHO JUDGES

A panel of working artists and educators from the Image Group's design faculty and invited industry professionals.

Exact dates are announced on the portal and by email to registered participants.

The back view is where honesty hides.